of years. The establishment would hold *her* – rather than Ganpat and Tukaram – responsible for the rape.

As word about the incident at Desaiganj police station spread, the crowd gathered there began to grow increasingly agitated. Head Constable Baburao was contacted as the crowds threatened to burn down the police station. He persuaded the crowd to disperse and registered an FIR. Mathura was left with no alternative but to give a detailed statement to the male colleague of the men who had raped and assaulted her.

She was examined by a doctor nearly twenty-four hours after the incident. The method of medical examination reeked of social prejudices by focusing attention on the sexual history of the victim. Doctors at the time conducted the 'two-finger' test on rape victims. The test postulated that inserting two fingers into the vagina would enable doctors to determine the 'laxity' of the vagina, and whether the hymen had already been ruptured. The implication of the vagina admitting two fingers relatively easily was twofold – first, that the woman was not a virgin and had been sexually active and second, that it was more likely than not that penetration had taken place.

After the case was filed and investigations completed, the case arose for decision before the sessions judge at Chandrapur, a town about 150 kilometres southwest of Desaiganj. The fact that the case reached this stage was an achievement in and of itself. Many women would not have had the resolve to file a complaint in the first place. Those that did would be pressured into withdrawing it once filed. But not Mathura. Mathura and the witnesses for the prosecution commuted to Chandrapur by bus during the trial.[1] Judgement day at the sessions court arrived on 1 June 1974, just over two years after the incident.

The judgement of the sessions court reaffirmed the beliefs of those thousands of women who chose not to pursue proceedings against their assailants. Ganpat and Tukaram were both acquitted, but what would have stung far more are the terms on which the judge acquitted them. Mathura was described as a 'shocking liar', whose testimony was 'riddled with falsehood and improbabilities'. The medical examination and the fact that there were no signs of a physical struggle, resistance, screams or protest